English punctuation: worked answers

16 original questions for 11 Plus skill preparation. Supports families preparing for tests taken in 2027; not an official paper, past paper or school-specific mock.

Scope: apostrophes and direct-speech punctuation. This set does not assess the full English syllabus.

Use untimed first. Check the method as well as the final answer. Return to the linked guide for teaching and further questions.

Find both booklets and online practice: https://www.11plusexampapers.com/papers

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Apostrophes

Passage for question 6:

Before the exhibition, one curator checked the artists’ labels. Two visitors left their umbrellas beside the children’s drawings. “It’s almost ready,” the curator said, lifting a model onto its stand. “We’ve only got the lights to test.”

Context: several artists and children are involved; there is one curator.

1. Rewrite “We have finished the display” using a contraction.

Answer: We’ve finished the display.

Why: We’ve contracts we have. The apostrophe marks the omitted letters in have.

2. One gardener owns several spades. Rewrite “the spades belonging to the gardener”.

Answer: the gardener’s spades

Why: There is one gardener, so the singular owner takes ’s. Spades is an ordinary plural.

3. Four musicians share a rehearsal room. Rewrite “the room used by the musicians” using possession.

Answer: the musicians’ rehearsal room

Why: Musicians is plural and already ends in s. Add the apostrophe after that s.

4. Rewrite “the helmets belonging to the children” using possession.

Answer: the children’s helmets

Why: Children is an irregular plural without a final s. Add ’s to children.

5. Complete: “The museum has changed ___ entrance, and ___ easier to find.”

Answer: its; it’s

Why: The first gap means the museum’s entrance. The second expands to it is easier to find.

6. In the exhibition passage, what two words does “It’s” replace?

Answer: It is

Why: The sentence means It is almost ready. It has almost ready would not be grammatical.

7. Correct this sentence: “The baker sold six loaf’s before lunch.”

Answer: The baker sold six loaves before lunch.

Why: This is a plural, not possession. The correct plural spelling is loaves, with no apostrophe.

8. Explain the difference between “the dancer’s shoes” and “the dancers’ shoes”.

Answer: The first refers to one dancer; the second to more than one dancer.

Why: Shoes is plural in both phrases. The changed apostrophe position changes the number of owners, not the number of shoes.

Source guide: https://www.11plusexampapers.com/blog/11-plus-apostrophes

Direct Speech Punctuation

9. Add punctuation: Leah said the lantern is in the cupboard

Answer: Leah said, “The lantern is in the cupboard.”

Why: The reporting clause comes first, followed by a comma. The spoken sentence begins with a capital and its full stop goes inside the closing speech mark.

10. Correct: “The bridge is safe.” he said.

Answer: “The bridge is safe,” he said.

Why: The reporting clause follows a spoken statement. Replace the full stop inside the speech with a comma; keep he lower case and end the whole sentence after said.

11. Add punctuation: where did you leave the map she asked

Answer: “Where did you leave the map?” she asked.

Why: This is a direct question. Capitalise Where, put the question mark inside the speech marks, and finish the reporting clause with a full stop. No additional comma follows the question mark.

12. Correct: “Stop”! shouted Arun.

Answer: “Stop!” shouted Arun.

Why: The exclamation mark is part of the speech and belongs before the closing speech mark. The reporting clause then completes the surrounding sentence.

13. Punctuate as one interrupted spoken sentence: if we leave now said Mei we can catch the bus

Answer: “If we leave now,” said Mei, “we can catch the bus.”

Why: Removing said Mei gives one sentence: If we leave now, we can catch the bus. Commas mark the reporting clause and we continues in lower case.

14. Punctuate as two complete spoken sentences: the rain has stopped said Mei we can go outside

Answer: “The rain has stopped,” said Mei. “We can go outside.”

Why: Each spoken sentence can stand alone. End the reporting clause with a full stop; begin the second spoken sentence with capital We.

15. Correct: “I found it,” Priya lifted the notebook.

Answer: “I found it.” Priya lifted the notebook.

Why: Lifted describes a separate action, not a speaking verb. The speech is a complete sentence, followed by the action sentence. Priya keeps its capital as a name.

16. Punctuate and paragraph this exchange: are you ready asked Ben almost replied Imani

Answer: “Are you ready?” asked Ben. “Almost,” replied Imani.

Why: Ben asks a question, so the question mark stays inside his speech marks. Imani is a new speaker and starts a new paragraph. Her short reply takes a comma before its reporting clause.

Source guide: https://www.11plusexampapers.com/blog/11-plus-direct-speech-punctuation